

enslavers provided their slaves with Christian instruction and “rescued” them from barbarism and heathenism.

Northerners, meanwhile, were fearful of this new militant defense of slavery. As West and East grew closer through railroads, telegraph, and print, the South was aggressively seeking to send slavery into new territories and states where it had been outlawed for decades. One response to this trend was the Free-Soil Party, established in 1848 under the slogan, “Free Soil, Free Speech, Free Labor, and Free Men.” Free-Soilers contended that a society where free men worked free soil was not only morally superior to a slave society, but also more efficient economically. By 1849, they had won 14 seats in the U.S. House of Representatives and two in the Senate.

At the same time, Northern workers feared economic competition from Black labor. As tens of thousands of European immigrants arrived in the North, urban crowding and a scarcity of work increased pressures on the free Black community there, with riots and mob actions from New England through the Midwest.

It was against this background that the federal government had to make a decision on the future of the territory acquired after the War with Mexico. The solution, the Compromise of 1850, consisted of five bills designed to balance the interests of North and South. These bills admitted California to the Union as a free state, thus ending the balance in the Senate between slave states and free states that had lasted since the Missouri Compromise of 1820—senators from the free states would now outnumber those from the slave ones. As a concession to the South, the territories of Utah and New Mexico were to choose slavery or freedom according to the principle of “popular sovereignty.” The Fugitive Slave Act, which had been federal law since 1793, was given new teeth. It became an offense, punishable by a large fine, for any citizen to resist or refuse to assist in the recapture of suspected runaways, even in states that opposed slavery.